AFTER THE ARMADA

THE SPANISH ARMADA of 1588 was a military fiasco and a maritime disaster, but in the 1590s Spain reasserted its status as the leading oceanic naval power. The English "Counter-Armada" of 1589 failed to exploit Spain's temporary weakness, and after that the willpower and resources of the Spanish state were marshaled to restore the strength of the Spanish navy. The overwhelming force sent to attack an English fleet off the Azores in 1591 was indicative of Spanish recovery, even as the resistance put up by Sir Richard Grenville and the *Revenge* exemplified the best of English fighting spirit. The Spanish were capable of sending further Armadas to attack England in 1596 and 1597. Although both were defeated by the weather before reaching their objective, they were a more serious threat to England than the English raid on Cadiz in 1596 was to Spain. For England, the deaths of Sir John Hawkins and Sir Francis Drake on a vain expedition to the Caribbean symbolized the end of an era. The accession of James I to the English throne in 1603 led to peace with Spain and a period of decline for the English navy.

ANGLO–SPANISH WARS

THE COUNTER-ARMADA



Date April–June 1589
Forces English: c.120 ships; Spanish: unknown
Losses Unknown

Location Coruña, Spain and Lisbon, Portugal

Flush with victory over the Armada, England sought to strike a decisive blow against a weakened Spain. An expedition was mounted with three ambitious goals: to destroy the Spanish ships refitting in northern Spain; to seize Lisbon and restore Portugal's independence; and to capture the Spanish treasure fleet from the Americas. Since the English state was broke, the expedition was financed as a joint-stock venture, with Queen Elizabeth as one of the investors. After endless delays a large fleet carrying 20,000 troops set out from England in April, with Sir Francis Drake and Sir John Norreys in command. Also on board, against the Queen's wishes, was her courtier the Earl of Essex.

The Counter-Armada was a fiasco from start to finish. It failed to attack the port of Santander, where most of the refitting Spanish fleet lay defenseless, instead taking Coruña, where the most notable prize was a damaging quantity of wine. The attempt to take Lisbon failed dismally: the population refused to rise against the Spanish and the expedition had no siege engines with which to breach the city's walls. The interception of the Spanish treasure fleet was foiled by Atlantic storms. Decimated by disease—as many as 10,000 men may have died – the fleet straggled home, to the special distress of its disappointed financial backers.



1532–1595

SIR JOHN HAWKINS

ENGLISH PRIVATEER AND ADMIRAL

Born in Plymouth, Hawkins was a privateer who pioneered English participation in the Atlantic slave trade in the 1560s. In 1577 he was appointed treasurer to the queen's navy. He was a fine administrator, making improvements in ship design and showing an admirable concern for sailors' welfare. Hawkins fought against the Armada as a vice admiral on board *Victory*, a service for which he was knighted. In the 1590s he was a leading advocate of an offensive strategy in the war with Spain. He died of disease on an expedition to the Caribbean in 1595.

The port of Lisbon
The Portuguese capital, under Spanish rule since 1580, was one of the main targets of the Counter-Armada, but the English failed to cause any damage.

